PRIMED & BOOKED

CONTRACTOR'S SETUP GUIDE

Your Google Business Profile.

The listing that decides whether a homeowner calls you or the next guy. Set it up right, on your phone, in about an hour.

Included free with every build.

This one is yours to do. Everything in here you can finish yourself. No account of ours, no waiting on us, no line item.

WRITTEN FOR CALIFORNIA HOME SERVICE CONTRACTORS · CURRENT AS OF AUGUST 2026

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What's in here

Fifteen sections. Each one finishes. Do them in order; a few of them depend on the one before.

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ONE THING THAT CHANGED

Google shut down the separate Business Profile dashboard. There is no app to download and no separate website to log into. **You manage everything from inside Google Search and Google Maps while signed in to your Google account.** If someone tells you to open the "GBP Manager," they're working off old information.

1 WHY THIS MATTERS

What this is, and why it decides who gets the call

A homeowner's water heater lets go at seven in the morning. They pull out their phone and type *plumber near me*. They do not scroll. They look at the three businesses Google puts on the little map, tap one, look at the photos for about four seconds, read the top review, and call.

That map listing is your Google Business Profile. It's free, and for most home service contractors it brings in more work than the website does.

Two things changed in 2026

Google took the one-tap call button off the mobile map this year, so a customer has to open your profile before they can call. Now they see your photos, your services, and your reviews before they decide.

And the old public Questions & Answers section is gone. Google's AI now answers customer questions on the spot, built from **your services list, your description, your reviews, and your photos.** When somebody asks Maps "do they paint cabinets" or "do they work in Rocklin," the answer comes from what you typed into your profile. Leave the services list empty and Google has nothing to answer with.

> **THE SHORT VERSION**
> Section 7, your services list, is the most valuable twenty minutes in this guide. Everything before it exists so you can get to it.

The whole thing costs nothing and takes about an hour. The only wait is verification, usually around five business days, and you can do every other section while you wait. Sit down somewhere with decent signal and your license next to you. The video is the one part you want to do calmly.

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2 BEFORE YOU START

Get these together first

Twenty minutes of gathering saves you an hour of stopping and starting. Lay it all out before you touch anything.

On your phone

- **A Google account you own and will keep.** Not a former employee's, not the one your nephew set up, not a marketing company's. If the only account tied to your business belongs to someone else, make a new one now with an email address you control.
- **Location turned on**, and Google Maps allowed to use it. Verification will fail without this.
- **A charged battery.** You'll be shooting video.

Written down

- **Your business name, exactly as it reads on the truck and on your invoices.** Character for character. If the truck says "Delgado Painting" then it's Delgado Painting, not "Delgado Painting Inc." and not "Delgado Painting & Drywall Sacramento."
- **Your CSLB license number and classification** (C-33, C-36, C-39, B, whatever yours is).
- **The cities you actually work in.** Write the list. You'll need up to twenty of them.
- **Your real hours.** When you answer the phone, not when you're awake.
- **Your business phone number and your website address.** The same ones printed on your invoices.
- **The year you started.**

Photos and files

- **At least 20 job photos** already on your phone. Finished work, in daylight, taken horizontally. Before-and-after pairs if you have them.
- **Your logo**, as a square image if possible.

- **A photo of your truck** with the business name visible on the door.

Documents you'll hold up on camera

You need paper that ties your name to your business at the address you're going to register. Pull two or three of these:

- Your CSLB pocket license card
- Certificate of liability insurance with the business name on it
- City or county business license
- A utility bill, lease, or mortgage statement showing the address
- A piece of mail addressed to the business at that address
- A printed invoice on your letterhead
- Vehicle registration or insurance for the branded truck

BEFORE YOU GO FURTHER

If you rent a mailbox at a UPS Store or use a coworking address, stop. Google will not verify it and using it is one of the fastest ways to get suspended. Register the address you actually operate from. Your home is fine, and Section 5 shows you how to hide it from the public.

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3 WHAT ALREADY EXISTS

Find out whether Google already has you

Google creates listings on its own, from directories, permits, and customer submissions. Most contractors who think they have no profile actually have one sitting there unclaimed. Check before you create anything.

Run three searches

1. Open the **Google Maps** app, signed in to your Google account. Search your business name plus your city.
2. Search your **business phone number** on its own. Old listings often survive under a number when the name has changed.
3. Search your **street address**. If a former business at your address never closed its listing, you want to know now.

You'll land on one of three outcomes. Find yours below, then go to the matching path in Section 4.

Outcome A: nothing comes up

No listing exists. You'll create one from scratch. Go to **Path A** in the next section.

Outcome B: your business is listed, but nobody owns it

You'll see your name on the map, and somewhere on the listing there's a line that says **Claim this business** or **Own this business?**. That link only appears on unclaimed listings. This is the good outcome: the listing already has some history with Google. Go to **Path B**.

Outcome C: it's listed and somebody else already claimed it

No claim link, and the listing may have hours or photos you didn't put there. Usually an old marketing company, a former partner, or a lead-generation outfit reselling your calls. You can take it back. Go to **Path C**.

DO NOT DO THIS

Don't create a second listing because the first is inconvenient to reclaim. Duplicates at the same address get flagged, and the usual outcome is that *both* get suspended. Reclaiming is slower but it's the only thing that works.

While you're in there: if you spot an old listing for a business you used to run at the same address, note it. You'll close it out in Section 14.

4 CLAIM IT

Three paths, depending on what you found

Path A: no listing exists

1. In Google Search, signed in, search **add my business to google**. Tap the result that lets you add your business.
2. Type your business name **exactly as it appears on the truck and your invoices.** No city, no services, no keywords. Section 11 explains why this one matters more than it looks.
3. Choose your primary category. Don't agonize. Section 6 covers this and you can change it.
4. When it asks **"Do you want to add a location customers can visit?"** answer **No**, unless you genuinely have a shop with a counter and walk-in customers. Almost every contractor answers No.
5. It will then ask where you serve customers. Enter your cities. You can refine this later.
6. Enter your phone number and website.
7. Google will ask for the address anyway, for verification. Enter your real one. It stays private. Section 5 covers hiding it.

You'll land straight in verification. Go to Section 5 before you tap anything else.

Path B: the listing exists but is unclaimed

1. Open the listing in Maps. Tap **Claim this business**.
2. Confirm you're the owner. Google will walk you through the same name, category, and location questions as Path A.
3. **Fix anything wrong on the way through.** Auto-generated listings frequently have a wrong phone number or an address Google guessed from a permit filing.
4. Continue into verification, Section 5.

Path C: someone else claimed it

This one takes longer. Start it today so the clock runs while you do everything else.

1. Open the listing in Maps and tap **Claim this business**. Google will tell you it's already claimed and offer **Request access**.
2. Fill in your name, your role at the business, and your contact details. Say plainly that you own the business and the current manager is a former vendor or employee.
3. Google emails the current owner. If they approve, you get it immediately. If they ignore it, they have **3 days** to respond. After that the request times out and you can claim the listing yourself.
4. Check the email you filed the request under. Google's response goes there, not to the profile.

> **TWO THINGS WORTH KNOWING**
>
> If you know who has the listing, just call and ask for it. A former marketing company will usually hand it over rather than deal with a dispute. One phone call beats a two-week wait.
>
> And never give a vendor ownership of your profile. That's how contractors end up in Path C. If you hire help, add them as a *manager*, never as the owner.

5 VERIFICATION

Getting verified with the video

This is the longest section and the one people fail. Read the whole thing before you start filming. It's tedious. Do it once, properly, and you're done.

SET UP FIRST | THEN FILM IN ONE TAKE | ~5 BUSINESS DAYS TO HEAR BACK

First: set yourself up as a service-area business

Do this before you film. What Google expects to see in your video depends on how your profile is configured, and getting this backwards is a common reason for rejection.

A service-area business is one that goes to the customer instead of the customer coming to you. That's you. Here's how it has to be set up:

1. **Register your real address.** Your home, your shop, wherever you actually operate. Google needs a verifiable address, and a real one is the whole point of the video.
2. **Then hide it from the public.** In your profile info, turn off showing the address to customers. Your profile will show your service areas instead of a street address, and no homeowner will see where you live.
3. **Add your service areas.** Cities, towns, or ZIP codes, up to twenty of them.

> **THE MISTAKE THAT GUARANTEES REJECTION**
> Listing your home as a storefront customers can visit. If you leave the address public and tell Google people come to you, the verification fails, and if it somehow passes, the listing gets suspended later. Answer **No** to the walk-in question and hide the address. Every time.

Picking service areas that don't hurt you

Keep them inside roughly a two-hour drive of your base. Wider than that and Google discounts the whole set. A painter in Roseville who lists San Diego is telling Google the list isn't real. List the cities you'd actually drive to on a Tuesday, and leave off the rest. Five real cities beats twenty made-up ones.

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5 VERIFICATION

The rules of the video

Video verification is now the standard path for small businesses. Google may still offer a mailed postcard code in some cases, but don't plan around it. Assume you're filming.

RULE	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU
Live capture only	You film through the Business Profile itself, on your phone, while it's recording. You cannot shoot it in your camera app and upload the file. There is no upload button.
Location permission on	Google reads your phone's location while you film and compares it to the address you registered. If location is off, the video is worthless before you start.
One continuous take	No stopping. No pausing. No editing. If you stop, you start over from the beginning.
30 seconds minimum	Usually you'll be under three minutes. Two minutes is a comfortable target.
Filmed at the registered address	Film at the address you gave Google. Not at a job site, not at your buddy's shop.
About five business days	That's the usual turnaround for a decision. Keep working through the rest of this guide while you wait.

What Google is actually checking

Three things, in this order:

1. **That the address is real** and you're standing at it.
2. **That a business operates there**: tools, trucks, equipment, a place where work gets organized.
3. **That the business is yours**: documents with your name and the business name on them.

Miss any one of the three and it fails. Most rejections are the third one: a perfectly good video of a truck and a garage, with nothing on camera that says who owns it.

> **REHEARSE FIRST**
> Walk the whole route once with your regular camera app. Time it. Find out that the license card is in the other truck *now*, not ninety seconds into the real take. Delete the rehearsal. Nobody sees it, it's just for you.

Set up before you hit record

- Daylight. Mid-morning is ideal. Never at dusk or under a single garage bulb.
- Wipe your camera lens on your shirt. Half of all blurry videos are a dusty lens.
- Lay your documents out flat on the tailgate or a workbench, in the order you'll film them, face up.
- Park the branded truck where you can walk to it without crossing a street.
- Open the garage or shop door.
- Hold the phone **horizontally** and move slowly. Slower than feels natural. Count to three on every shot.

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5 VERIFICATION

The shot list: film it in this order

Roughly two minutes, one take, no stopping. Narrate out loud as you go; Google accepts the audio and it helps.

0:00 — **The street**
Start at the curb. Film the street sign at the corner, then pan to the numbers on your house or building. Say the full address out loud: "This is 1420 Oak Street, Roseville, California."

0:15 — **The approach**
Walk toward the property, filming as you go. Mailbox with the number, driveway, front of the building. Don't cut. Keep walking and keep filming.

0:30 — **Your truck**
The business name on the door. The license plate. The ladder rack, the reel, the tanks. Say "This is our work truck." Circle it slowly. If you have two, film both.

0:50 — **Tools and equipment**
Into the garage, shop, or trailer. Sprayers, compressors, racked ladders, drop cloths, pipe, wire, fittings, stock on the shelves, labeled bins. Whatever your trade runs on. This is the part that proves a real business operates here.

1:15 — **Where the paperwork happens**
The desk, the computer, the printer, the file drawer, the whiteboard with next week's jobs on it. It does not have to be a fancy office. A corner of the garage with a desk in it is fine. It has to exist and be on camera.

1:35 **Documents: the part everyone skips**

Hold each one still, filling the frame, for a slow count of four. Your CSLB pocket card. Your insurance certificate. Your business license. A printed invoice with your letterhead. A piece of mail addressed to the business at this address. Say what each one is as you show it.

2:05 **Finish**

Say your business name and the address one more time. Stop recording. Submit.

What gets videos rejected

PASSES

- One unbroken take, moving slowly
- Address numbers clearly readable
- Business name visible on a truck or sign
- Documents held still long enough to read
- Filmed in daylight at the registered address
- Location permission granted

FAILS

- Stopped and restarted, or edited
- Pre-recorded footage (there's no way to upload it anyway)
- Location services off
- Filmed somewhere other than the address you gave
- No documents tying you to the business
- An empty garage with no branding at all
- Too dark, too fast, too shaky to read anything

THEN WAIT

You'll usually hear back within about five business days, by email and in the profile itself. Don't refilm while you're waiting and don't start a second listing. Go straight on to Section 6. Everything from here can be done before verification comes through.

6 CATEGORIES

Pick one primary category and get it right

The most common reason a real, verified, well-reviewed business doesn't show up for the searches it should is a wrong primary category. It's a thirty-second decision that shapes everything after it.

How they work

Your **primary category** tells Google what your business fundamentally is, and it carries more weight than everything else combined. When someone searches "roofer near me," Google is mostly choosing between businesses whose primary category is the roofing one. **Secondary categories** are additional things you do. They help, but each one spreads you a little thinner.

The rule

Your primary category is the work that pays most of your bills. Not the work you want more of. The work you actually do most.

A painter who does some drywall repair is a *Painter*. If you pick "General contractor" because it feels bigger, you'll disappear from every painting search in your county and never know why.

IF YOU MOSTLY DO	SET YOUR PRIMARY TO
Interior and exterior painting	Painter
Roof repair and replacement	Roofing contractor
Residential plumbing	Plumber
Heating and air	HVAC contractor
Residential electrical	Electrician
Full-scope remodels and additions	General contractor

Google's category list is a fixed menu. Start typing and pick the closest match it offers. You can't invent one. Every label in the table above was checked against Google's current list in August 2026.

Secondary categories

Add only what you genuinely do and would happily take a call for. Two to five is a healthy range. Some examples:

- **Painter**: cabinet refinishing, drywall contractor, deck builder *(only if you actually do them)*
- **Plumber**: water heater installation, drainage service, gas installation service
- **Roofing contractor**: gutter service, siding contractor, skylight contractor

You get one primary category plus up to nine secondary ones, ten in total. Whatever you add, make sure your services list in the next section backs it up. A category you claim with no matching services underneath it is the kind of mismatch that draws a suspension.

DON'T DO THIS

Don't add every category that sounds adjacent to your trade. It doesn't get you into more searches. It waters down the one search you should be winning, and "category mismatch" is on Google's list of suspension causes.

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7 SERVICES

Your services list: the most important hour

If you only do one section of this guide properly, do this one. Give it twenty focused minutes.

Why this changed everything

The old Questions & Answers section (where customers asked things and anyone could answer) was retired at the end of 2025. What replaced it is **Ask Maps**. A customer types a real question ("do they paint kitchen cabinets," "do they work in Lincoln," "how much for a water heater") and Google's AI writes an answer on the spot.

It builds that answer out of your services list, your description, your reviews, and your photos. Nothing else. There's no box where you answer questions yourself anymore.

WHAT THIS MEANS IN PLAIN TERMS

Every service you didn't write down is a service Google will tell customers you don't offer. Every service you wrote down as two bare words is a service Google can barely describe. The contractor with twelve fully-written services wins the question, and the customer never sees the one with three.

How to write them

1 **List every service you'd take a call for.** Not five. Get to ten or fifteen. Sit down and think through the last year of jobs.

2. **Name it the way a customer says it.** "Popcorn ceiling removal," not "acoustic texture remediation." "Water heater replacement," not "domestic hot water system installation." Customers search in their words, and so do they ask in their words.
3. **Write a real description for every single one.** Two or three sentences. What's included, roughly how long it takes, who it's for. This is the part that gets skipped and it's the part that does the work.
4. **Say your city once or twice across the whole list**, not in every description. Natural, not stuffed.
5. **Include prices or ranges if you're comfortable.** "Most interior repaints run $3,000 to $7,000." Google will use it, and it filters out the tire-kickers before your phone rings.

Keep each description tight: a short paragraph, not an essay. Google caps each one at **300 characters**, which is about the length of the examples below.

> **THE TEST**
> Read your finished list and ask: if a stranger read only this, would they know exactly what I do and whether I'd take their job? If yes, you're done. If they'd have to call to find out, write more.

7 SERVICES

Filled-out examples

Written the way yours should look. Copy the shape, not the words. Swap in your own cities, crew, and prices.

Painter

Interior Painting
Walls, ceilings, trim, and doors in occupied homes. We mask floors and cover furniture before any can is opened, and we clean up at the end of every day, not at the end of the job. Two coats standard. A typical three-bedroom takes three to four days.

Exterior Painting
Full exterior repaints on stucco, wood siding, and fiber cement. Includes pressure washing, scraping loose paint, caulking gaps, and priming bare spots before we spray. We use paint rated for Central Valley sun, and we don't paint in the heat of the afternoon.

Cabinet Painting and Refinishing
Kitchen and bathroom cabinets sprayed to a factory-smooth finish. Doors come off and get sprayed in our shop; boxes are done on site with the kitchen sealed off. Most kitchens run five to seven days start to finish. Cheaper than replacing and it looks like new.

Drywall Repair and Patching
Holes, cracks, water damage, and nail pops repaired, textured to match your existing wall, and painted. We match orange peel, knockdown, and smooth. Small repairs are usually a same-day job.

Popcorn Ceiling Removal
Old textured ceilings scraped, skim coated smooth, and painted. We seal off the room and protect everything below. Homes built before 1980 get tested first. We don't scrape anything until asbestos results come back clean.

Deck and Fence Staining
Decks, fences, and pergolas cleaned, sanded where needed, and stained or sealed. We'll tell you honestly whether the wood is worth coating or whether you're better off replacing boards first.

Commercial Painting
Offices, retail spaces, and apartment turns in Roseville and the surrounding area. We schedule around your hours, including nights and weekends, so we're not painting while your customers are standing there.

Examples, continued

Plumber

Water Heater Replacement
Tank and tankless water heaters removed and replaced, including the permit, the new pan, the earthquake straps, and hauling the old unit away. Most standard tank swaps are done in a single morning. We stock common sizes so you're not waiting on a part.

Drain Cleaning
Kitchen, bath, laundry, and main line clogs cleared by cable or hydro jetting. If the same drain keeps backing up, we'll run a camera before we charge you to clear it again. A repeat clog usually means something is broken, not dirty.

Leak Detection and Repair
Slab leaks, wall leaks, and under-sink leaks located with acoustic and pressure testing before anything gets opened up. We find it first, show you, then give you a price to fix it.

Repiping
Whole-house repipes in copper or PEX for homes with failing galvanized or leaking copper. We work room by room, patch the drywall behind us, and most houses are done in three to five days with water on every night.

Sewer Line Camera Inspection
Camera run through your main line to see exactly what's happening: roots, a belly, a break, or just buildup. You get to watch the screen with us, and you get the footage. Standard before buying an older home.

Emergency Plumbing
Burst pipes, no hot water, sewage backups, and anything actively flooding. We answer the phone after hours and tell you honestly whether it can wait until morning or whether we're coming now.

Roofing contractor

Roof Repair
Leaks traced to the actual source, not just patched where the ceiling stain is. Missing shingles, cracked flashing, failed valleys, and pipe boot replacement. We photograph everything on the roof and show you before we quote.

Roof Replacement
Full tear-off and replacement in composition shingle, tile, or standing seam metal. Includes new underlayment, flashing, and vents, plus permit and haul-away. Most single-story homes are three to four days.

Free Roof Inspection
A written report with photos on the condition of your roof and how many years you've realistically got left. Useful before buying, before selling, or after a storm. We'll tell you when a roof still has ten years in it.

Gutter Installation and Repair
Seamless aluminum gutters formed on site, plus downspouts and leaf guards. Fixes the overflow that's staining your siding and soaking your foundation.

OTHER TRADES

HVAC: AC repair · AC installation · furnace repair · furnace installation · heat pump installation · duct cleaning and sealing · thermostat installation · maintenance plans. **Electrician:** panel upgrades · EV charger installation · recessed lighting · ceiling fan installation · outlet and switch repair · whole-house rewiring · generator hookup · troubleshooting. Same rule: write two or three real sentences under every one.

8 DESCRIPTION

The business description

You get 750 characters, about a short paragraph and a half. It shows on your profile and it's one of the sources Google's AI answers customers from, so it's worth ten real minutes.

What goes in it

- Who you are and what trade you're in
- The cities you cover
- Your top three services
- One honest sentence about how you work that the next guy couldn't copy
- Your CSLB license number

What stays out: slogans, "we're passionate about quality," anything you'd be embarrassed to say to a customer's face, and keyword lists. Google strips promotional junk anyway and it reads badly to the person you're trying to win.

Fill-in-the-blank template

TEMPLATE

[Business name] is a licensed and insured **[trade]** serving **[main city]**, **[city]**, and **[city]** since **[year]**.

We do **[service one]**, **[service two]**, and **[service three]** for **[homeowners / property managers / both]**.

[One sentence on how you actually work: who shows up, how you quote, what you do that others don't.]

[One sentence on the business: owner-operated, crew size, family run, years in the trade.]

CSLB License #**[number]**. Call or text for a free estimate.

Two finished examples

PAINTER: 612 CHARACTERS

Delgado Painting is a licensed and insured painting contractor serving Roseville, Rocklin, Lincoln, and the Sacramento area since 2011. We handle interior and exterior repaints, cabinet refinishing, and drywall repair for homeowners and property managers.

Every estimate is walked and priced by the owner, not a salesman, and you get the same two-man crew from the first day to the last. We cover floors and furniture before a can is opened and we clean up every evening, not just at the end.

Family owned, ten years in the trade, and we still answer our own phone. CSLB License #987654. Call or text for a free estimate.

PLUMBER: 641 CHARACTERS

Harker Plumbing is a licensed and insured plumbing contractor serving Fresno, Clovis, and Madera since 2008. We do water heater replacement, drain cleaning, leak detection, and whole-house repipes for homeowners and small commercial properties.

We give you a flat price before we start, so what we quote is what you pay even when the job runs long. If we find something that can safely wait, we'll tell you it can wait.

Owner-operated with three trucks, and someone answers the phone after hours for real emergencies. CSLB License #123456. Call or text and we'll tell you honestly when we can get there.

9 HOURS & CONTACT

Hours, service areas, and contact info

The boring section. It's also the one that quietly costs people work, because a wrong detail here contradicts everything else Google knows about you.

Hours

Put in the hours you **answer the phone**, not the hours you're awake.

- If someone answers at 7am, say 7am. Customers call contractors early.
- Only mark yourself **Open 24 hours** if a live human answers at 2am. Showing "open" and not picking up produces the one-star review that starts "called three times, nobody answered."
- Set **special hours** for Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Year's, and the Fourth. Two minutes, and it stops Google telling customers you're open when you're not.
- Closing for a week in the summer? Put it in.

Service areas

Set up back in Section 5. Worth repeating: **twenty maximum**, inside roughly a two-hour drive, and only cities you'd really drive to. Padding the list doesn't get you into those searches. It just tells Google the list isn't trustworthy.

Name, address, phone: keep them identical everywhere

Google cross-references your business against your website, your invoices, directory listings, your CSLB registration, and old records. When those disagree, Google trusts all of them less.

FIELD	MAKE SURE
Name	Character-for-character the same on your profile, your website, and your invoices. Not "Delgado Painting" in one place and "Delgado Painting LLC" in another.
Address	Formatted the same everywhere. Pick "Ste 4" or "Suite 4" and use it consistently. Registered with Google, hidden from the public.
Phone	One primary number, and the same one that's on your website and your truck. A local area code beats a toll-free number.
Website	Point it at your homepage. Include the https and make sure the link actually loads.

ON CALL TRACKING NUMBERS

If you ever use a tracking number, it goes in the *secondary* phone slot, never the primary. Your real, published business number stays primary. A tracking number that appears nowhere else on the internet makes your profile look inconsistent to Google.

Messaging

Google's own chat feature has been retired. There's no built-in messaging inbox to keep up with anymore. If you want customers to be able to message you, add the **WhatsApp contact button**. Only do it if you'll actually reply. An ignored message is worse than no button.

10 PHOTOS

Photos

Google now weighs how people interact with your profile (photo views, review reads, clicks through to your site) more heavily than it used to. Photos are what people actually look at. This is fifteen minutes of uploading and it moves the needle.

What to upload, and how many

TYPE	HOW MANY	WHAT IT SHOULD BE
Logo	1	Square, clean, readable at thumbnail size.
Cover photo	1	Your best finished job or your branded truck. This is the first thing a customer sees.
Truck and equipment	2–3	Business name visible. Proves you're real.
The team	1–2	You and your crew, in shirts, at a job. Homeowners are deciding who they'll let in the house.
Finished work	15–20	Your actual jobs. Range of work, range of homes.
Before and afters	3–5 pairs	Upload each pair back to back so they sit next to each other.

How to shoot them

- **Horizontal.** Google crops vertical photos badly.
- **Daylight, no flash.** Open the blinds for interiors.
- **Wipe the lens first.** Every time.
- **Stand back** and get the whole room or elevation. A close-up of a corner means nothing.
- **Shoot the before before you unload the truck.** Once you've started, it's gone.
- **Same spot for the after.** That's what makes the pair work.
- **Tidy up first**: drop cloths moved, hoses coiled, tape pulled.

DO

- Real jobs you personally did
- A mix of interiors, exteriors, and details
- Wide shots that show the whole space
- A few photos a month, forever

DON'T

- Stock photos: Google removes them and customers spot them
- Screenshots, flyers, or images with text pasted over them
- Heavy filters or anything that looks retouched
- Other companies' logos, license plates, or house numbers in frame
- Customers or their kids without asking first
- Twenty photos on day one and nothing for two years

THE HABIT THAT MATTERS

Two photos a month beats twenty photos once. Google reads a profile with no new photos in a year as a business that may not be operating. Take two shots on your way out of a finished job and upload them from the truck. That's the whole routine.

11 CALIFORNIA

Two California specifics

Short section, but the second one is the most common way a good contractor loses a profile.

Your CSLB license number

California requires your license number on your business materials, and homeowners here are used to looking for it. It also gives Google something verifiable to tie you to.

Put it in three places:

- **The last line of your business description**: "CSLB License #987654."

- **Your website**, in the footer on every page.
- **Your invoices and estimates**, where it's required anyway.

Use the same format everywhere. Include your classification if you have room for it: C-33 for painting, C-36 plumbing, C-20 HVAC, C-10 electrical, C-39 roofing.

Keep your business name clean: this is the big one

Your Google business name must be **your actual business name and nothing else**. Not your name plus your city. Not your name plus your services. Not your name plus "Best" or "24/7" or "#1."

ALLOWED

- Delgado Painting
- Harker Plumbing & Drain
- Sierra Ridge Roofing

GETS YOU SUSPENDED

- Delgado Painting Roseville Interior Exterior Painters
- Harker Plumbing: Best Plumber in Fresno 24/7
- Sierra Ridge Roofing | Roof Repair & Replacement

Keyword-stuffed names are the number one cause of contractor suspensions, and it's enforced automatically now. It also doesn't work. Google discounts the extra words and your competitors can report you in about ten seconds.

Use the name that's on the truck, on your invoices, and on your CSLB registration. If you operate under a DBA, use the DBA exactly as it's registered.

THE OTHER SUSPENSION CAUSES, WHILE WE'RE HERE

- An address Google can't verify
- A virtual office, mailbox store, or coworking address
- A service-area business showing a public street address
- Duplicate listings for the same business
- Categories that don't match what you actually do

12 REVIEWS

Reviews, done legally

Google tightened the review rules in April 2026 and enforcement is automatic now. Reviews collected the wrong way are being deleted in bulk, sometimes months later, and the profile that collected them gets a black mark. Read this before you ask anybody for anything.

What is banned as of April 2026

BANNED	WHAT THAT LOOKS LIKE
Incentives of any kind	A discount, a gift card, a free service call, a raffle entry, money off the next job: anything offered in exchange for a review. Even "leave us a review and we'll knock $25 off."
Review quotas for staff	Telling your crew they need to bring in five reviews a month, or tying a bonus to review counts.
Asking to be named	"Mention Danny in your review." Banned, even though it's a nice thought.
Kiosks and shared devices	A tablet at your shop or in your truck for customers to leave reviews on. Multiple reviews from one device get stripped.
Gating	Asking how the job went first and only sending the review link to the ones who say "great."
Fake or bought reviews	Reviewing yourself, having family review you, buying them, trading with another contractor. Long banned, now caught faster.

WHY THIS MATTERS MORE THAN IT SOUNDS

Enforcement is automated. Google doesn't warn you. The reviews simply disappear, and a business that loses a batch of reviews gets looked at harder from then on. Two years of legitimate reputation can go with the bad batch.

The compliant method: this is all you need

1. **Get your review link.** Open your profile in Google Search while signed in and use the option to ask for reviews. It gives you a short link. Save it in your phone's notes so it's one tap away.
2. **Ask everyone.** Not just the happy ones. Asking every customer is what keeps you out of gating trouble, and it's what makes your rating real.
3. **Ask once, at the right moment**: the same day the job is finished, when you've walked it with them and they're pleased. Not a week later.
4. **Ask from your own phone, by text or email**, with the link. Their device, their words, no incentive attached.
5. **Never follow up more than once**, and never offer anything to change their mind.

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12 REVIEWS

Two templates you can use as-is

TEXT MESSAGE: SEND THE DAY THE JOB WRAPS

Hi [first name], thanks for having us out today. If you've got a minute, a quick Google review helps other folks in [city] find us: [your review link]

Either way, appreciate the business. Call me if anything comes up.

[your name], [business name]

EMAIL: SAME DAY OR NEXT MORNING

Subject: Thanks from [business name]

Hi [first name],

Thanks for having us out to [short description of the job]. It came out well and it was good working with you.

If you have a minute, we'd appreciate an honest Google review. It's the main way homeowners around [city] find us, and it takes about a minute:

[your review link]

And if anything about the work isn't right, call me first and I'll come fix it.

Thanks,
[your name]
[business name] · [phone]
CSLB License #[number]

Notice what isn't in either one: no discount, no gift card, no request to name anybody, no "if you're happy" filter. That's deliberate. Both are compliant exactly as written. Change the bracketed parts and nothing else.

Things that will get your reviews deleted

- Offering anything at all in exchange
- Asking customers to mention a specific employee
- Setting review targets for your crew
- A tablet or shared phone that customers leave reviews on
- Standing over someone while they type it
- Sending fifty requests at once from one device

- Only asking the customers you know are happy
- Asking friends and family who never hired you

Responding: do this every time

Respond to every review, good and bad, within a couple of days. Google counts it, and more importantly the next customer reads it.

GOOD REVIEW

Thanks, **[name]**, glad the **[job]** came out the way you wanted. Call us any time.

BAD REVIEW

[Name], I'm sorry it went that way. That's not how we run jobs. I'd like to make it right. Please call me directly at **[phone]** and I'll come take a look myself.

Short, calm, no arguing, no explaining yourself in six paragraphs. The reply isn't for the angry customer. It's for the hundred people who read it afterward and decide whether you're the kind of outfit that shows up when something goes wrong.

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13 UPKEEP

Keeping it alive: 15 minutes a month

Google reads an untouched profile as a business that might not be operating, and it weighs activity more heavily now than it used to. Fifteen minutes a month keeps everything you just built working.

The monthly routine

DO THIS	TAKES	DETAILS
Post once	5 min	A finished job, a seasonal note, an opening in the schedule. Two or three sentences and a photo. That's a post.
Add two photos	2 min	Straight off your phone, from the last job you finished.
Answer every review	5 min	All of them, good and bad. Two sentences each.
Check your info	3 min	Hours right? Phone right? Any service you started offering that isn't on the list yet?

Put it on the calendar for the first Monday of the month. It's genuinely fifteen minutes, and it's the difference between a profile that keeps producing calls and one that quietly fades.

What to post about, when you're stuck

- A job you just finished, with one photo and where it was
- Seasonal work: "exterior season is here," "before the rain hits"
- An opening in next week's schedule
- A service most people don't know you do
- A straight answer to a question you get asked constantly

Don't overthink it. Nobody's grading the writing.

Twice a year, spend twenty minutes

- Reread your services list. Add what's new, delete what you stopped doing.
- Update the description: year count and cities.
- Set special hours for the holidays coming up.
- Search your own name in Maps and look at the profile the way a customer sees it.

THE ONE HABIT WORTH BUILDING

Two photos and one review request per finished job, sent from the truck before you drive off. Do that and the monthly fifteen minutes takes five.

14 TROUBLESHOOTING

If something goes wrong

Your verification video was rejected

It happens, and it's usually fixable in one round. Google's rejection notice is vague, so work down this list:

1. Was **location permission** on the whole time? This is the most common cause.
2. Did you **stop and restart**? Even a two-second pause can invalidate it.
3. Were the **address numbers actually readable**: not blurry, not in shadow, not filmed while walking?
4. Did you film at the **registered address**, not a job site?
5. Did you show **documents with your name and the business name** on them, held still long enough to read?
6. Was there **anything branded on camera**: a truck door, a sign, a shirt?

Fix the specific thing, then refilm. Don't submit the same video again. It'll fail the same way. If Google offers a different verification method after a failure, take it. Rejected twice with everything above covered? Use the support option in your profile and ask for a human review, with your CSLB number and a utility bill ready to send.

Your profile got suspended

FIRST, DO NOT DO THIS

Do not create a new listing. That turns one suspended profile into a duplicate problem on top of a suspension, and it makes reinstatement much harder. Fix the existing one.

1. **Find the cause before you appeal.** Nine times out of ten it's one of these: keywords in the business name, an address Google can't verify, a virtual or mailbox address, a service-area business with a public street address, a duplicate listing, or categories that don't match the business.
2. **Fix it first.** Strip the name back to what's on the truck. Hide the address. Remove the categories you don't actually work in. Appealing without fixing anything gets denied.
3. **Then file the appeal** using Google's Business Profile appeals tool, which is linked from the suspension notice and from Google's help pages. Be short and factual: what the business is, where it operates, what you corrected. If you attach evidence, be ready before you start: once the evidence form opens, you have 60 minutes to submit it or it won't be attached.
4. **Attach proof.** CSLB license, business license, insurance certificate, a utility bill at the address, a branded truck photo, an invoice on your letterhead.
5. **Wait.** Most appeals come back within 3 to 5 business days. Don't file again while one is open, and don't create a second listing in the meantime. Either one slows you down or makes it worse.

There's a duplicate listing for your business

Usually an old auto-generated listing, or one from a previous business name at the same address.

1. Open the duplicate in Maps.
2. Use the option to suggest an edit or report a problem, and mark it as a duplicate or as permanently closed.
3. If the duplicate is the one with all your reviews on it, don't close it. Claim it and ask Google to merge it into the correct listing. Reviews follow a merge; they don't survive a closure.

Someone left a review that's obviously fake

Report it through the review itself and let it run. Don't argue with it in the reply. Reply once, calmly, the way Section 12 shows, and move on. One strange review against twenty real ones reads as one strange review.

15 CHECKLIST

The whole thing on one page

Tear this out and work down it. Everything except the verification wait fits in about an hour.

BEFORE YOU START

- [ ] Google account I own and will keep
- [ ] Location turned on, phone charged
- [ ] Business name exactly as on the truck
- [ ] CSLB number and classification
- [ ] List of cities I work in
- [ ] Real hours, phone, website
- [ ] 20+ job photos and my logo
- [ ] Two or three business documents pulled

FIND AND CLAIM

- [ ] Searched my name, my phone, my address in Maps
- [ ] Identified which of the three outcomes I'm in
- [ ] Claimed it, or filed the access request
- [ ] Did NOT create a duplicate listing

VERIFICATION

- [ ] Set up as a service-area business
- [ ] Real address registered
- [ ] Address hidden from the public
- [ ] Service areas added (20 max, 2-hour drive)
- [ ] Documents laid out, lens wiped, daylight
- [ ] Rehearsed the route once
- [ ] Filmed live, one take, held horizontally
- [ ] Showed street, truck, tools, desk, documents
- [ ] Submitted

CATEGORIES

- [ ] One primary: the work that pays the bills
- [ ] 2–5 secondaries, all things I really do

SERVICES: THE BIG ONE

- [ ] 10–15 services listed
- [ ] Named the way customers say them
- [ ] Every one has a real 2–3 sentence description
- [ ] City mentioned once or twice, not stuffed
- [ ] Prices or ranges where I'm comfortable

DESCRIPTION

- [ ] Written, under 750 characters
- [ ] Cities, top three services, how I work
- [ ] CSLB number on the last line
- [ ] No slogans, no keyword lists

DETAILS

- [ ] Hours = when I answer the phone
- [ ] Holiday special hours set
- [ ] Name, address format, phone identical everywhere
- [ ] Website link loads
- [ ] Business name has zero keywords in it

PHOTOS

- [ ] Logo and cover photo
- [ ] Truck, equipment, the crew
- [ ] 15–20 finished jobs
- [ ] 3–5 before/after pairs, uploaded back to back
- [ ] No stock photos, no screenshots

REVIEWS

- [ ] Review link saved in my phone
- [ ] Text template saved
- [ ] No incentives, no quotas, no kiosk, no name-drops
- [ ] Asking every customer, not just the happy ones

EVERY MONTH

- [ ] One post
- [ ] Two photos
- [ ] Reply to every review
- [ ] Check hours and info

THAT'S THE WHOLE JOB

Done properly, this profile will out-earn most of what contractors pay for. It's yours, it stays yours, and nothing in here needed anyone's help.